Priyanka and Rahul, by contrast, had lived a sheltered existence—family tragedy and perhaps personal choices had made them wary of the daily hardships of politics. Priyanka, for example, was married at twenty-five and became a mother two years later. Politics in the twenty-first century demands a near-complete blurring of the lines between your private and political life. The need for privacy is an obstruction for an individual seeking to win the unrelenting battle to capture hearts and minds, and in the end family concerns invariably give way to political ambition. Modi, Mamata, Mayawati, Jayalalithaa, Naveen, Nitish are all good examples of the modern neta—single men and women for whom politics is all-consuming.

While Priyanka focused on her children, the BJP's priorities were very different. The party had achieved what it had set out to do—send out a message that no seat anywhere in UP, not even Amethi, was unwinnable in 2014. But there was one even bigger battle that the Modi–Shah duo had their eyes firmly focused on—the battle for Varanasi.

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Varanasi, Kashi, Banaras—many names for one of the most ancient and complex cities in the world, nestled on the banks of the great river Ganga. A city of poets and pandits; of sages and mafia; of philosophers and politicians. Ancient Hindu texts describe Varanasi as heaven on earth; a modern-day traveller is more likely to associate this corner of eastern UP with the idea of a living hell.

The Ganga feels holy at dawn, by dusk it resembles a sewer. Banarasi saris look gorgeous at weddings, but the weavers who make them work out of tiny, powerless tenements. You feel a sense of tranquillity at the ghats during the Ganga *aarti*, but your stress levels will rise while dodging the city's outrageous traffic. The Banaras Hindu University (BHU) once produced scholar-statesmen; now it is trapped in sloth and decay. You can live here in awe of the city's intellect but also in fear of the gun-toting